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Loughborough University CoARA Action Plan

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Version 1.1 October 2023

Preamble

Loughborough University joined the Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in February 2023. As a signatory to the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) that underpins the Coalition, Loughborough commits to sharing how we have started the process of reviewing and developing criteria, tools and processes in line with the core Commitments according to an action plan with defined milestones, within one year of signing the Agreement.

Loughborough University has a strong history of engagement with responsible research assessment (RRA) and was one of the first universities in the UK to develop a Responsible Metrics Policy back in 2016. To an extent, therefore, many of the Commitments required by the ARRA are ‘business as usual’ for the institution. However, the University continuously strives to do better and to contribute nationally and internationally to this important agenda. Our CoARA Action Plan therefore embeds existing RRA practice at Loughborough and outlines further actions to ensure we continually remain abreast of best practice and play a significant role in the promotion of RRA globally.

Commitment	Scope	Action	Timeframe
1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research Purpose: This commitment will broaden recognition of the diverse practices, activities and careers in research, considering the specific nature of research disciplines and other research endeavours.	Changes in assessment practices should enable recognition of the broad diversity of: - valuable contributions that researchers make to science and for the benefit of society, including diverse outputs beyond journal publications and irrespective of the language in which they are communicated; - practices that contribute to robustness, openness, transparency, and the inclusiveness of research and the research process including: peer review, teamwork and collaboration; - activities including teaching, leadership, supervision, training and mentoring. It is also important that	1.1 Develop a new Responsible Research Assessment Policy that makes explicit the requirements of the ARRA. 1.2 Work with SHAPE disciplines to develop guidance for the fair assessment of a broad range of practice- and non-journal-article outputs which can be applied to all disciplines. 1.3 Work to include new output guidance in internal researcher assessment processes.	February 2023 February 2023 By October 2023

	assessment facilitates the recognition and valorisation of diverse roles and careers in research, including: data steward, software engineer and data scientist roles, technical roles, public outreach, science diplomacy, science advice and science communicator roles to name a few. It is recognised that current practice is often too narrow and limiting, so the goal cannot be to replace the narrow criteria we wish to move away from with different but equally narrow criteria. Instead, the aim is to allow organisations to broaden the spectrum of what they value in research, while acknowledging that this may vary across disciplines and that each individual researcher should not be expected to contribute to all activities at once.	1.4 Ensure a wider range of contributions are also recognised as part of internal researcher assessment processes. 1.5 Develop Publication Ethics guidance that requires researchers to credit all contributions to research outputs, possibly via the use of CRediT.	By February 2024 By February 2024
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators Purpose: This commitment will enable the move towards research assessment criteria that focus primarily on quality, while recognising that responsible use of quantitative indicators can support assessment where meaningful and relevant, which is context dependent.	Research assessment should rely primarily on qualitative assessment for which peer review is central, supported by responsibly used quantitative indicators where appropriate. Peer review is the most robust method known for assessing quality and has the advantage that it is in the hands of the research community. It is important that peer review processes are designed to meet the fundamental principles of rigor and transparency: expert assessment, transparency, impartiality, appropriateness, confidentiality, integrity and ethical considerations, gender, equality and diversity. To address the biases and imperfections to which any method is prone, the research community re-assesses and	2.1 Ensure peer review activity is listed as a Scholarly Activity on LUPIN 2.2 Consider whether peer review activity on LUPIN could be surfaced via PDR 2.3 Provide guidance on open peer review and peer review credit systems. 2.4 Consider a university training offer on journal and/or output peer review See also: 1.2, 1.3, 1.4	By June 2023 By December 2023 By December 2023 By Summer 2024

	improves peer review practices regularly. Revised, or potentially new, criteria, tools and processes appropriate for assessing quality could be explored alongside peer review. Moving towards assessment practices that rely more heavily on qualitative methods may require additional efforts from researchers. Researchers should be recognised for these efforts and their contributions to reviewing peers' work should be valued as part of their career progression.		
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index Purpose: This commitment will reduce the dominance of a narrow set of quantitative journal and publication-based metrics	Inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics in research assessment should be abandoned. In particular, this means moving away from using metrics like the Journal Impact Factor (JIF), Article Influence Score (AIS) and h-index as proxies for quality and impact. 'Inappropriate uses' include: • relying exclusively on author-based metrics (e.g. counting papers, patents, citations, grants, etc.) to assess quality and/or impact; • assessing outputs based on metrics relating to publication venue, format or language; • relying on any other metrics that do not properly capture quality and/or impact	3.1 Update the training video for LU staff on responsible research assessment and use of metrics, noting disciplinary differences 3.2 Continue to monitor adherence to Loughborough University Responsible Research Assessment Policy See also: 1.1, 1.2, 1.3	By Easter 2024 Ongoing commitment
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment Purpose: This commitment will help avoid that metrics used by international rankings, which are inappropriate for assessing researchers, trickle down to research and researcher assessment. It will help the research community and research organisations regain	Recognising that the international rankings most often referred to by research organisations are currently not 'fair and responsible', the criteria these rankings use should not trickle down to the evaluation of individual researchers, research teams and research units. Research organisations should also be mindful that public communication (e.g. the active advertising of an institution's rank) can contribute to the perception that research quality conflates with ranking positions. Where	4.1 Promote Loughborough's signatory status to the INORMS More Than Our Rank initiative alongside any ranking-related promotion activity. 4.2 Commit staff resource to promoting More Than Our Rank more globally.	By December 2024 Ongoing commitment

the autonomy to shape assessment practices, rather than having to abide by criteria and methodologies set by external commercial companies. This could include retaining control over ranking methodologies and data.	ranking approaches are deemed unavoidable, as may be the case in forms of evaluation beyond the scope of this Agreement such as benchmarking and performance reviews of countries or institutions, the methodological limitations of such approaches should be acknowledged, and institutions should avoid trickle-down effects on research and researcher assessment.	See also: 1.1	
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to Purpose: This commitment will ensure that organisations allocate the necessary resources, whether in the form of budget or staff capacity, to improve research assessment practices within their agreed timeframe.	Resource allocation by assessment authorities and research funding and performing organisations is a necessary condition for reforming assessment practices. Resources should be allocated as is needed for each organisation to achieve the changes that will enable adherence to the Principles and to implement the Commitments. This includes resources to: • implement changes in research assessment, including planning and progress monitoring; • raise awareness among all actors; • educate, train and support researchers and any other staff involved in assessment, including peer-reviewers and assessors; and • support the necessary infrastructure such as tools and services for the transparent collection and processing of data on research assessment practices. Particular attention should be paid to making resources available to enable the engagement of researchers at all career stages in reforming research assessment.	5.1 Create a new Head of Research Culture & Assessment post with a specific remit to engage with national and international RRA policy agendas. 5.2 Support for responsible research assessment to form a specific aspect of the Research Culture & Quality Manager's job description. Hours may vary over the year.	Ongoing commitment Ongoing commitment
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Scope: Criteria for the assessment of research performing units and organisations, including universities, research centres, and research infrastructures, should be reviewed and adapted, and new criteria developed where needed,	6.1 Continue to 'evaluate with the evaluated' in accordance with LU RRA Policy: "wherever possible, research assessments will be designed and	Ongoing commitment

6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability Purpose: This commitment will ensure that national / regional / organisational authorities and evaluation agencies review and, where needed, develop criteria for the assessment of research performing units and organisations, in accordance with the Principles. It will foster the responsible use of metrics in assessing research performing units and organisations, and help to prevent contradictions or incompatibilities between the assessment of research, researchers and research performing organisations. It will also safeguard the interoperability of adapted or newly developed assessment processes.	based on evidence. This should be done in close collaboration with assessors and those that will be assessed, including research organisations and researchers. The changes should increase the ability to assess quality by enabling recognition of all contributions to quality research by research units and institutions. Such recognition includes that of early sharing of data and results, open collaboration, teamwork; and consideration of contributions to the research ecosystem, knowledge generation and scientific, technological, economic, cultural and societal impact. National / regional / organisational authorities and evaluation agencies should coordinate to ensure their methodologies and processes are interoperable, while simultaneously respecting the necessary adaptation to each context.	interpreted with the communities under evaluation. In particular, we will ensure that those evaluated will be able to verify any analysis and underlying data that relates to them."	
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes 6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application	Scope: Criteria, tools and processes should be reviewed and developed together with researchers in different disciplines and at different career stages; and should enable recognition of the diversity of research activities and practices that contribute to research quality, including diverse outputs in different languages. This should increase the ability to assess quality by enabling recognition of all contributions to quality research from research projects and by researchers and research teams. This includes recognition of early sharing of data and results, open collaboration, and teamwork. Reformed practices for assessing individual researchers should consider future potential alongside track record and take into account researchers' individual contexts and careers.	6.2 Continue to monitor and review internal promotion, probation, appraisal criteria to ensure they meet our internal RRA Policy which takes in the ARRA. See also 6.1 and 1.2, 1.3 and 1.4	Ongoing commitment

Purpose: This commitment will enable recognition of the diverse research activities and practices through the revision and development of assessment criteria, tools, and processes. It will ensure that organisations review their processes and make tangible changes by developing existing or new assessment approaches, individually or in collaboration with others, in accordance with the Principles	They should also recognise that researchers cannot excel in all types of tasks and provide for a framework that allows researchers to contribute to the definition of their research goals and aspirations. Research assessment by research funders should consider disciplinary, multi-, inter-, and trans-disciplinary research as well as contributions to knowledge generation and scientific, technological, economic, cultural and societal impact		
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use Purpose: This commitment will ensure that organisations raise awareness of the reform among all actors. It will ensure that organisations transparently communicate the criteria, tools and processes used for research assessment and train researchers and assessors in their use.	Scope: Without widespread awareness of the reform and training of those assessed and, crucially, assessors, progress will be slow - if not impossible. Organisations should be clear and transparent about assessment processes and the tools and criteria they use. They should make guidance on their assessment approaches openly available and train those involved in the assessment process. They should allow those assessed to have access to the criteria, data and reviews or deliberation outcomes used in their assessment within the limits of confidentiality. Particular attention should be paid to raising awareness among researchers at all career stages.	7.1 Incorporate research assessment reform as a key pillar of ongoing work on research & innovation culture at Loughborough University. 7.2 Head of Research Culture Research Quality & Culture Manager to seek opportunities to write, speak and advise on RRA in national & international fora.	By Easter 2024 Ongoing commitment once appointed.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition Purpose: This commitment will ensure organisations exchange and make use of information for mutual learning. It will help avoid fragmentation, contribute to the coherence of assessment practices between organisations, and enable researcher mobility. It also will allow those further ahead to share approaches and lessons learned, to benefit those who have further to go on their reform journey.	Scope: While respecting each other's autonomy, organisations should share practices and experiences to facilitate mutual learning. This exchange should include contributing to the development of guidance and common approaches in order to minimise contradictions or incompatibilities between the assessment practices used by different organisations. It should also include sharing of lessons learned to ensure continuous mutual improvements	8.1 Explore the possibility of establishing and joining a National Chapter of CoARA in the UK. 8.2 Play an active role in at least one CoARA Working Group.	By Easter 2024 From Autumn 2023

9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments Purpose: This commitment will ensure organisations update one another on the progress made. It will foster careful self-reflection and monitoring of their own adherence to the Principles and progress towards meeting the Commitments.	Scope: Demonstrating progress made towards implementing the Commitments and adherence to the Principles is an important part of this initiative. Organisations should commit to regularly update each other and their communities on their adherence and progress. This process involves being open to scrutiny from their own communities, sharing successes as well as challenges, and communicating their experiences to facilitate collective progress.	9.1 Publish our CoARA Action Plan on the LU RRA web pages once approved. 9.2 Annually report back on progress via the Action Plan and update it as necessary.	Autumn 2023 Autumn 2024 and ongoing
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research Purpose: This commitment will ensure that assessment approach decisions are evidence informed. It will help organisations reflect on their own processes, gain understanding about whether assessment practices achieve the desired goals and engage in evolutive assessment based on new evidence as it becomes available. It will also help to ensure control and ownership of research assessment data by the research community.	Scope: Growing evidence shows that current assessment processes that rely on publication and journal-based metrics are prone to multiple biases. As approaches using more qualitative research assessment are piloted by several organisations (e.g. narrative and evidence-based CVs, new assessment frameworks and indicators), it is important to evaluate and monitor their impact based on evidence and rigorous methods. Organisations should contribute to the evidence base on research assessment in order to make this possible. For example, it could be achieved by making data that can be used for research on research available, by participating in research on research, or by funding research on research. Data sharing should be the minimum commitment and data should be shared through open infrastructure, while respecting personal data protection.	10.1 Head of Research Culture & Assessment & Research Culture & Quality Manager to remain abreast of latest evidence and best practice in RRA.	Ongoing commitment.

Dr Elizabeth Gadd, July 2023